VANTAGE MOVERS · RESOURCES

Comparing two written moving estimates

Put the inventories side by side first. Use this printable worksheet to find differences in services, access, storage and terms before choosing a mover.

Explore moving guides

Make the two offers describe the same move

If one estimate includes the patio set, packing the kitchen and a flight of stairs while the other leaves them out, their totals answer different questions. Mark each difference, then ask for the agreed inventory, services and terms in writing. FMCSA's moving checklist directs consumers to compare both costs and services and to check the companies' registration.

Write each company's legal name, contact information and USDOT number at the top of your own copy. Record the estimate date and revision. Ask which company will transport the shipment, then check that company separately from any broker.

How to use the blank worksheet

For every row, write the actual wording or a document reference. Write 'not stated' when an item is missing; a blank is not an inclusion. Use the open-questions row to record who will answer and when. Ask for a revised written estimate if the scope changes, and keep the old version with your notes.

- Use the same pickup and delivery addresses, dates and inventory for both requests.
- Separate what is included, optional, excluded and still unconfirmed.

- Compare estimate type, payment schedule, cancellation terms and shipment protection as well as the total.
- Read the applicable documents before signing; this worksheet does not replace them.

Worked example: a lower initial number covers less work

Fictional exercise only. Alex and Sam are moving a two-bedroom household with 40 boxes, a patio set, kitchen packing, one flight of stairs and a seven-day storage gap. Offer A is invented at $4,800 and includes that scope. Offer B is invented at $4,100 but leaves four items out. Every dollar below is made up to demonstrate arithmetic; these are not Vantage prices, market rates or a quote.

In the exercise, B's writer supplies hypothetical additions of $175 for the patio set, $450 for kitchen packing, $125 for stairs and $100 for the seven-day storage gap. The additions total $850. On those fictional assumptions, B becomes $4,950, which is $150 above A. In a real comparison, only the provider's revised written estimate can supply these amounts. Do not fill unknown charges with this example's numbers.

The decision still needs written answers

Even after matching scope, a total does not settle everything. In the example, Alex and Sam still need to confirm the assigned carrier, estimate terms, delivery arrangements and what happens if storage lasts longer. They request those answers and updated documents before choosing. You can use the same process without submitting this worksheet or your personal move details to Vantage.

Worked comparison

Fictional worked comparison — invented amounts for arithmetic only, not rates or a price promise

Item to compare	Fictional offer A	Fictional offer B
Matched household inventory	Two-bedroom inventory, 40 boxes and patio set listed.	Same household and boxes; patio set omitted initially. Fictional correction: +$175.
Packing labor and materials	Kitchen packing listed as included.	Kitchen packing excluded initially. Fictional addition: +$450.
Stairs / long carries	One flight included; no long carry assumed at either address.	Stairs omitted initially. Fictional addition: +$125. Same no-long-carry assumption needs confirmation.
Storage	Seven days listed as included.	Storage excluded initially. Fictional addition for seven days: +$100.
Redelivery	One delivery after the seven-day gap included in this exercise.	One delivery after the seven-day gap included in this exercise. Extra attempts remain a question.
Original invented total	$4,800	$4,100
Invented additions to match scope	$0	$175 + $450 + $125 + $100 = $850
Comparable invented total	$4,800	$4,100 + $850 = $4,950
Still open before choosing	Assigned carrier; estimate type; payment/cancellation terms; extended storage; protection terms.	Same questions, plus a revised written estimate showing all four additions.

In this fictional example the $700 lower initial figure becomes $150 higher after matching scope. Get the real provider's written answers; neither amount predicts your move's cost.

Compare your own estimates

Item to compare	My estimate A	My estimate B
Company, USDOT number, contact and estimate date/revision		
Assigned carrier and broker (if any)		
Pickup / delivery addresses and dates		
Matched inventory and box count		
Packing labor, materials and unpacking		
Stairs, elevator, long carry and access assumptions		
Storage period, access and extension terms		
Redelivery, notice and additional attempts		
Estimate type and written total		
Payment schedule and cancellation terms		
Valuation / protection and claim procedure		

Item to compare	My estimate A	My estimate B
Open questions, answer owner and follow-up date		

Sources and review

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FMCSA: Movers vs. Brokers (opens a new tab)

FMCSA: Moving Checklist (opens a new tab)

FMCSA: Search for a Registered Mover (opens a new tab)

Your next step

Long-distance moving →

Compare the belongings, services and access in each written estimate. Bring your route and preferred dates to a Vantage quote conversation.

Storage questions →

Ask about storage availability for your shipment, access while stored, handling charges and the process for scheduling delivery.

Before the inventory call →

Walk through every room and storage space. Separate what is moving, what needs packing help and what will stay with you.

Who handles my move? →

Keep three roles clear: you describe the shipment, Vantage coordinates the request, and the assigned motor carrier transports the goods.